



Social Psychology (SOCPSY)

Module 3: Social Perception

Attribution and Bias

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

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Attribution

Attribution is explaining the cause of behaviour. Internal or dispositional attribution points to the person: personality, ability, or effort. External or situational attribution points to the situation: luck, other people, or circumstances.

Example: "He failed because he is lazy" is internal. "She failed because the exam was unfair" is external.

Fundamental Attribution Error

The fundamental attribution error is the tendency to over-attribute others' behaviour to personality and under-estimate the situation. A common traffic example: someone cuts you off and you think "terrible driver," yet when you cut someone off you explain it as being late.

Self-Serving Bias

Self-serving bias means we credit successes to internal factors and failures to external factors. It protects self-esteem, but it can block learning if you never accept useful feedback.

Reflect: Recall a recent group project. How did you explain success or failure for yourself versus for another member?

Closing

Attribution shapes everyday judgment. The next lesson covers impression formation and bias.